LAI Hao Ran

SE Asia Rainforest Research Partnership (SEARRP)
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Education

2015–2018 Ph.D., Ecology and Evolutionary Biology, National University of Singapore. Advisors: Michiel van Breugel & Hugh Tan Tiang Wah. Thesis: *Functional ecology of tropical secondary forests*.

2009–2012 B.Sc. (Hons.) Ecology, The University of Queensland. Advisor: Margaret M. Mayfield. Thesis: *Functional recovery following logging in subtropical forests*.

Career summary

I am a quantitative ecologist and data scientist with over 10 years of research and teaching experience in spatial modelling and vegetation mapping. I have taught **spatial ecology** and biostatistics, twice won the **Best Teaching Assistant Award** (NUS), and supervised 6 PhD, 4 MSc and 8 undergraduate students. I have 13 peer-reviewed publications in Q1 journals as first or corresponding author. My 39 publications have been collectively cited 1,424 times with an h-index of 16. My projects have been funded by the ForestGEO Research Award (USD 10,000) and the Marsden Fast Start Fund (NZD 360,000).

Employment

2026–present Part-time lecturer, University of Nottingham Malaysia
— GEOG1019 Introduction to GIS

2024–present Ecologist–Data Scientist, South East Asia Rainforest Research Partnership (SEARRP), Malaysia (joint appointment by Imperial College London, UK)
— Virtual Ecosystem (digital twin)
— Spatial validation of process-based ecological models in Borneo

2019–2025 Research Fellow, School of Biological Sciences, University of Canterbury, New Zealand
— Species distribution and spatial modelling

2019 Visiting Research Fellow, Centre for Urban Greenery and Ecology, National Parks Board, Singapore
— Spatial patterns of tree diameter growth in urban streetscapes

2018–2019 Research assistant, Department of Biological Sciences, National University of Singapore, Singapore
— Freshwater swamp forest survey and mapping

2015–2018 Teaching assistant, National University of Singapore, Singapore
— *Please see Teaching section for taught courses.*

2015 Biology Olympiad trainer, National Junior College, Singapore

2012–2014 Research officer, The University of Queensland, Australia
— Mapping of endangered plant species

2012–2014 Course Tutor, The University of Queensland, Australia
— *Please see Teaching section for taught courses.*

Teaching

2026	Introduction to GIS
2025	Bayesian statistics for ecologists
2015–2018	Field Studies in Biodiversity, Ecology of Terrestrial Environments, Tropical Horticulture, Quantitative Methods for Ecological Research, Comparative Botany, Ecology and the Environment, Biodiversity
2012–2014	Biostatistics, Ecology, Plant Biology

Supervision & Mentoring

2026	Pin Jia Chan (PhD), Rose Foster-Dyer (PhD)
2025	Daniel Hernández (PhD), Felicia Wei Shan Leong (PhD), Tim Logan (MSc.)
2024	Sophie O'Brien (PhD), Gabrielle Koerich (PhD), Jack Anderson (MSc.)
2023	Laura van Ginkel (MSc.), Rory Lennox (MSc.)
2017	Zhong Yu Chiam (BSc. Hons)
2016	Melissa Wong Qi Yun (BSc. Hons), Amanda Ng Wei Ling (BSc. Hons), Pin Jia Chan (Undergraduate programme), Zhong Yu Chiam (Undergraduate programme), Rens Gerard Brouwer (Undergraduate programme), Srishti Arora (Undergraduate programme)
2015	Germaine Tan Su Yin (BSc. Hons)

Publications

∗ *denotes spatial- and mapping-related publications.*

Peer-reviewed articles

∗ Lai, H. R., Chong, K. Y., Neo, L., Wardle, D. A., Vesk, P. A. (2026). Asymmetric transferability of trait–environment relationships between native and exotic plant species in Singaporean forests differing in land-use history. *Oikos*, e12302.

Chan, P. J., Elliott, T., Lai, H. R., Burns, B., Schwendenmann, L. (2026). Consequences of a dieback disease on carbon stocks and fluxes in forests dominated by a susceptible foundation species. *Plant Ecology*, 227(9).

∗ Chan, P. J., Hu, K., Elliott, T., Lai, H. R., Burns, B., Schwendenmann, L. (2026). Dieback Disease Increases Short-Term Spatial Heterogeneity and Litterfall Inputs in Forests Dominated by a Long-Lived Foundation Species. *Ecosystems*, 29(6).

∗ Ooi, M. Y., Ho, Y. Y., Lai, H. R., Yee, A. T. K., Chong, K. Y. (2026). Forest dynamics during the thinning phase of succession following a severe windstorm in a hurricane-free tropical forest. *Journal of Tropical Ecology*, 42.

Bufford, J. L., Brandt, A. J., Sprague, R., Buddenhagen, C. E., Duncan, R. P., Harcourt, N., Hulme, P. E., Lai, H. R., McAlpine, K. G., McGrannachan, C., Thomson, F. J., Uitregt, V. van, Peltzer, D. A. (2026). Mechanisms and impacts of future plant invasions: research agendas and management needs under disruptive social-ecological change scenarios. *Oikos*, e11984.

∗ Koerich, G., Lai, H. R., Lee, C. K., Morgan, F. J., Tonkin, J. D. (2026). Proximity to seabird colonies and water availability shape moss distributions in Antarctica. *Ecography*, 2026(1), e08166.

Hernández-Carrasco, D., Gillis, A. J., Lai, H. R., Siqueira, T., Tonkin, J. D. (2026). Accounting for the Influence of Community Turnover Along Environmental Gradients on Compositional Uniqueness. *Ecology Letters*, 29(2), e70338.

Lai, H. R., Burcham, D. C., Wang, J. W., Stouffer, D. B., Qiu, D. W., Yee, A. T. K. (2025). Quantifying life-history trade-offs in diameter growth for tropical tree species from a large urban inventory dataset. *Urban Forestry and Urban Greening*, 112, 128982.

∗ O'Brien, S. A., Tylianakis, J. M., Anderson, D. P., Boesing, A. L., Lai, H. R., Le Provost, G., Manning, P., Neyret, M., Blüthgen, N., Jung, K., Magdon, P., Müller, S., Schenk, N. V., Scherer-Lorenzen, M., Lavorel, S. (2025). Mobile species' responses to surrounding land use generate trade-offs and synergies

among nature's contributions to people. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences of the United States of America*, 122(45), e2505401122.

Lai, H. R. (2025). Model-based ordination for phenological studies: From controlling sampling bias to inferring temporal associations. *Methods in Ecology and Evolution*, 16, 1542–1546.

Chan, P. J., Lai, H. R., Burns, B. R., Schwendenmann, L. (2025). Potential effects of an emerging disease on tree communities around a susceptible foundation tree species. *Austral Ecology*, 50, e70102.

∗ Herbert, S. M., Tomscha, S. A., Lai, H. R., Benavidez, R., Balkwill, C. G., Ruston, P. R., Jackson, B., Deslippe, J. R. (2025). Identifying potentially suitable and accessible refugia to mitigate impacts of an emerging disease on a rare tree. *Conservation Biology*, e70088.

Dehling, D. M., Lai, H. R., Stouffer, D. B. (2025). Eltonian niche modelling: applying joint hierarchical niche models to ecological networks. *Ecology Letters*, 28(6), e70120.

Lai, H. R., Hill, T., Stivanello, S., Chapman, H. M. (2025). Changes in quantity and timing of foliar and reproductive phenology of tropical dry-forest trees under a warming and drying climate. *Journal of Ecology*, 113(6), 1560–1572.

∗ Lai, H. R., Chong, K. Y., Wong, M. Q. Y., Tan, H. T. W., Yeo, D. C. J. (2025). Litter Depth, Not Canopy Openness, Mediates the Occurrence of an Invasive Shrub From the Forest Edge to Interior. *Biotropica*, 57, e70002.

∗ Lai, H. R., Bellingham, P. J., McCarthy, J. K., Richardson, S. J., Wiser, S. K., Stouffer, D. B. (2024). Detecting Nonadditive Biotic Interactions and Assessing Their Biological Relevance among Temperate Rainforest Trees. *American Naturalist*, 204(2), 105–120.

∗ O'Brien, S. A., Anderson, D. P., Lavorel, S., Lai, H. R., de Burgh, N., Tylianakis, J. M. (2024). Landscape patterns drive provision of nature's contributions to people by mobile species. *Journal of Applied Ecology*, 61, 2666–2678.

∗ Martins, L. P., Garcia-Callejas, D., Lai, H. R., Wootton, K. L., Tylianakis, J. M. (2024). The propagation of disturbances in ecological networks. *Trends in Ecology and Evolution*, 39(6), 558–570.

∗ Radford Smith, J., Lai, H. R., Cathcart-van Weeren, E., Dwyer, J. (2024). A Functional Basis for the Assembly of Australian Subtropical Rainforest Tree Communities. *Ecology Letters*, 27, e70014.

∗ Lai, H. R., Chong, K. Y., Yee, A.T.K. (2022). Ten years after: what we learned from the Mandai storm forest. *Nature in Singapore*, Supplement(e2022121), 207–218.

∗ Hall, J. S., Plisinski, J. S., Mladinich, S. K., van Breugel, M., Lai, H. R., Asner, G. P., Walker, K., Thompson, J. R. (2022). Deforestation scenarios show the importance of secondary forest for meeting Panama's carbon goals. *Landscape Ecology*, 37(3), 673–694.

Lam, W. N., Chan, P. J., Ting, Y. Y., Sim, H. J., Lian, J. J., Chong, R., Rahman, N. E., Tan, L. W. A., Ho, Q. Y., Chiam, Z., Arora, S., Lai, H. R., Ramchunder, S. J., Peh, K. S. H., Cai, Y., Chong, K. Y. (2022). Habitat Adaptation Mediates the Influence of Leaf Traits on Canopy Productivity: Evidence from a Tropical Freshwater Swamp Forest. *Ecosystems*, 25(5), 1006–1019.

Lai, H. R., Chong, K. Y., Yee, A. T. K., Mayfield, M. M., Stouffer, D. B. (2022). Non-additive biotic interactions improve predictions of tropical tree growth and impact community size structure. *Ecology*, 103(2), e03588.

∗ Lai, H. R., Tan, G. S. Y., Neo, L., Kee, C. Y., Yee, A. T. K., Tan, H. T. W., Chong, K. Y. (2021). Decoupled responses of native and exotic tree diversities to distance from old-growth forest and soil phosphorus in novel secondary forests. *Applied Vegetation Science*, 24(1), e12548.

Lai, H. R., Craven, D., Hall, J. S., Hui, F. K. C., van Breugel, M. (2021). Successional syndromes of saplings in tropical secondary forests emerge from environment-dependent trait–demography relationships. *Ecology Letters*, 24(9), 1776–1787.

∗ Falster, A. D., Gallagher, R., Wenk, E., Wright, I., Indiarto, D., ..., Lai, H. R., ... Kasia Ziemińska. (2021). AusTraits – a curated plant trait database for the Australian flora. *Nature Scientific Data*, 8(1), 254.

∗ Song, X. P., Lai, H. R., Wijedasa, L. S., Tan, P. Y., Edwards, P. J., Richards, D. R. (2020). Height-diameter allometry for the management of city trees in the tropics. *Environmental Research Letters*, 15(11), 114017.

Lai, H. R., Chong, K. Y., Yee, A. T. K., Tan, H. T. W., van Breugel, M. (2020). Functional traits that moderate tropical tree recruitment during post-windstorm secondary succession. *Journal of Ecology*, 108(4), 1322–1333.

∗ Yee, A. T. K., Lai, H. R., Chong, K. Y., Neo, L., Koh, C. Y., Tan, S. Y., Seah, W. W., Loh, J. W., Lim, R. C. J., van Breugel, M., Tan, H. T. W. (2019). Short-term responses in a secondary tropical forest after a severe windstorm event. *Journal of Vegetation Science*, 30(4), 720–731.

Chiam, Z., Song, X. P., Lai, H. R., Tan, H. T. W. (2019). Particulate matter mitigation via plants: Understanding complex relationships with leaf traits. *Science of the Total Environment*, 688, 398–408.

∗ van Breugel, M., Craven, D., Lai, H. R., Baillon, M., Turner, B. L., Hall, J. S. (2019). Soil nutrients and dispersal limitation shape compositional variation in secondary tropical forests across multiple scales. *Journal of Ecology*, 107(2), 566–581.

Wainwright, C. E., HilleRisLambers, J., Lai, H. R., Loy, X., Mayfield, M. M. (2019). Distinct responses of niche and fitness differences to water availability underlie variable coexistence outcomes in semi-arid annual plant communities. *Journal of Ecology*, 107(1), 293–306.

Lam, W. N., Lai, H. R., Lee, C. C., Tan, H. T. W. (2018). Evidence for pitcher trait-mediated coexistence between sympatric Nepenthes pitcher plant species across geographical scales. *Plant Ecology and Diversity*, 11(3), 283–294.

Bimler, M. D., Stouffer, D. B., Lai, H. R., Mayfield, M. M. (2018). Accurate predictions of coexistence in natural systems require the inclusion of facilitative interactions and environmental dependency. *Journal of Ecology*, 106(5), 1839–1852.

Lai, H. R., Hall, J. S., Batterman, S. A., Turner, B. L., van Breugel, M. (2018). Nitrogen fixer abundance has no effect on biomass recovery during tropical secondary forest succession. *Journal of Ecology*, 106(4), 1415–1427.

Wainwright, C. E., Staples, T. L., Charles, L. S., Flanagan, T. C., Lai, H. R., Loy, X., Reynolds, V. A., Mayfield, M. M. (2018). Links between community ecology theory and ecological restoration are on the rise. *Journal of Applied Ecology*, 55(2), 570–581.

∗ Sams, M. A., Lai, H. R., Bonser, S. P., Vesk, P. A., Kooyman, R. M., Metcalfe, D. J., Morgan, J. W., Mayfield, M. M. (2017). Landscape context explains changes in the functional diversity of regenerating forests better than climate or species richness. *Global Ecology and Biogeography*, 26(10), 1165–1176.

Lai, H. R., Hall, J. S., Turner, B. L., van Breugel, M. (2017). Liana effects on biomass dynamics strengthen during secondary forest succession. *Ecology*, 98(4), 1062–1070.

Lai, H. R., Mayfield, M. M., Gay-des-combes, J. M., Spiegelberger, T., Dwyer, J. M. (2015). Distinct invasion strategies operating within a natural annual plant system. *Ecology Letters*, 18(4), 336–346.

Software

Lai, H. R.. (2026) `MYtraits`: A trait database for the Malaysian flora.

Lai, H. R.. (2025) `SGtraits`: A trait database for the Singapore flora (v0.0.2). *Zenodo*.

Virtual Ecosystem Project Team. (2024) `Virtual Ecosystem`.

Lai, H. R., Chong K. Y., Yee A. T. K. (2020) `novelforestSG`: Data and model for Lai, Chong et al. (2020) *Appl. Veg. Sci.* R package version 2.0.

Song, X. P., Lai, H. R. (2020) `allometree`: Allometric Scaling of Urban Trees. R package version 0.1.

Conferences & Presentations

2026	Future Ecosystems Research Network. Macquarie University and University of New South Wales, Australia.
2025	Invited talks. National University of Singapore and National Parks Board Singapore.
2024	Ecological Society of Australia. Melbourne, Australia.
2022	sUCCESS secondary forest workshop. Leipzig, Germany.
2022	Association of Tropical Biology and Conservation (ATBC). Cartagena, Colombia.
2020	International Statistical Ecology Conference (ISEC). virtual.
2018	Association of Tropical Biology and Conservation (ATBC). Kuching, Malaysia.
2016	Conservation Asia. Singapore.
2015	20th Biological Science Graduate Congress. Bangkok, Thailand.

Grants, Awards & Scholarships

2026–2027	Forest Global Earth Observatory Research Award (USD 10,000), The Smithsonian Institute, USA
2022–2025	Marsden Fast Start Fund (NZD 360,000), Royal Society Te Apārangi, New Zealand
2019	International Society for Plant Molecular Biology Medal for most outstanding thesis
2019	CUGE Visiting Research Fellowship, National Parks Board Singapore
2017 & 2018	Teaching Assistant Award, National University of Singapore
2016	City Developments Limited (CDL) Urban Ecology and Conservation Scholarship
2013	University Medal, University of Queensland
2011	Summer Research Scholarship, University of Queensland
2010	D.A. Herbert Prize in Botany & F.A. Perkins Prize in Entomology, University of Queensland

Services & Outreach

Membership	Association of Tropical Biology and Conservation (ATBC), Open Traits Network (OTN), Ecological Forecast Initiative (EFI)
Peer review	*Science*, *Journal of Ecology*, *Functional Ecology*, *Ecology*, *Methods in Ecology and Evolution*, *Ecological Applications*, *Ecography*, *Biodiversity and Conservation*, *Biological Invasions*, *Science of the Total Environment*, *Journal of Vegetation Science*, *Global Ecology and Biogeography*, *Global Change Biology* etc.
2020	`RMarkdown` tutorial, University of Canterbury, New Zealand
2017	Science Research Programme, Hwa Chong Institution, Singapore
2016	Festival of Biodiversity, Singapore Botanic Gardens

Languages

English, Bahasa Malaysia, Mandarin, Cantonese

Other skills

Geographic information system (with QGIS and R), spatial modelling, Bayesian inference, version control (GitHub), plant survey and identification

Professional references

Robert Ewers (current post-doc supervisor)
Professor, Imperial College London, United Kingdom
South East Asia Rainforest Research Partnership (SEARRP), Malaysia
Email: r.ewers@imperial.ac.uk

Jason Tylianakis (former post-doc supervisor & ongoing collaborator)
Professor, University of Canterbury, New Zealand
Email: jason.tylianakis@canterbury.ac.nz

Michiel van Bruegel (former PhD supervisor & ongoing collaborator)
Associate Professor, National University of Singapore, Singapore
Email: yncmvb@nus.edu.sg

Alison Kim Shan Wee
Associate Professor, University of Nottingham Malaysia
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Cedric Tan Kai Wei
Associate Professor, University of Nottingham Malaysia
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